Setback Bidding Charts

How high to bid, from your trump holding: 4-handed and 6-handed

How to read a chart

- **Pick your trump suit**: the suit you'd name if you win the bid, usually your best.
- **Find your row**: which of the **A, K, Q, J** of that suit you hold.
- **Find your column**: whether you also hold the **10** and/or the **2** of that suit. "No 10 or 2" means you hold neither.
- **Read the cell**: three numbers, for **bid 2 · bid 3 · bid 4**. Each is how many **small trumps** (3 through 9 of your trump suit) you need for that bid. **0** means none needed; **–** means never, however many you hold.
- **Count your small trumps and bid the highest level you have enough for.** If you don't have enough for 2, pass.

The colour of a cell shows what you can bid with **no** small trumps. Every small trump you hold can only move you up from there, never down.

pass	bid 2	bid 3	bid 4

Examples

4-handed	A♠ 7♠ 5♠ + three other cards	row A, column "no 10 or 2": 0 · 1 · –	2 small trumps: enough for 3 → **bid 3**
4-handed	K♠ J♠ 4♠ 3♠ + two others	row K J, "no 10 or 2": 0 · 0 · 2	2 small trumps: enough for 4 → **bid 4**
4-handed	Q♥ 8♥ + four others	row Q, "no 10 or 2": 0 · 4 · –	1 small trump: 2 yes, 3 needs 4 → **bid 2**
6-handed	K♦ 6♦ + four others	row K, "no 10 or 2": 1 · – · –	1 small trump: enough for 2 → **bid 2**
6-handed	K♦ alone in diamonds	same cell: 1 · – · –	no small trumps → **pass**
6-handed	J♣ 5♣ 2♣ + three others	row J, column "+ 2": 1 · 2 · –	1 small trump → **bid 2** (one more for 3)

What "should bid" means

A bid is on the chart when, on average, it **gains your team points**: the points you take when you make it outweigh losing the bid when you're set. The chart gives the **highest** such bid, which is the most you should go to in the auction. If a lower bid wins the auction, bid that: in whole-game simulations, raising only as far as you need beat jumping straight to your highest bid.

Hands right at a boundary are close calls, and either bid is fine. Off-suit Aces can tip a close call up a level (page 4).

4-handed (two teams of two)

Each cell: small trumps (3–9) needed to **bid 2** · **bid 3** · **bid 4**. Colour = what you can bid with no small trumps.

Your trump honors	no 10 or 2	+ 10	+ 2	+ 10 and 2
A K Q J	0 · 0 · 0	0 · 0 · 0	0 · 0 · 0	0 · 0 · 0
A K Q	0 · 0 · –	0 · 0 · –	0 · 0 · –	0 · 0 · –
A K J	0 · 0 · 0	0 · 0 · 0	0 · 0 · 0	0 · 0 · 0
A Q J	0 · 0 · 0	0 · 0 · 0	0 · 0 · 0	0 · 0 · 0
K Q J	0 · 0 · 0	0 · 0 · 0	0 · 0 · 0	0 · 0 · 0
A K	0 · 0 · –	0 · 0 · –	0 · 0 · –	0 · 0 · –
A Q	0 · 0 · –	0 · 0 · –	0 · 0 · –	0 · 0 · –
A J	0 · 0 · 1	0 · 0 · 0	0 · 0 · 0	0 · 0 · 0
K Q	0 · 0 · –	0 · 0 · –	0 · 0 · –	0 · 0 · –
K J	0 · 0 · 2	0 · 0 · 0	0 · 0 · 0	0 · 0 · 0
Q J	0 · 0 · 4	0 · 0 · 1	0 · 0 · 2	0 · 0 · 0
A	0 · 1 · –	0 · 0 · –	0 · 0 · –	0 · 0 · –
K	0 · 2 · –	0 · 1 · –	0 · 1 · –	0 · 0 · –
Q	0 · 4 · –	0 · 2 · –	0 · 2 · –	0 · 0 · –
J	0 · 2 · –	0 · 0 · –	0 · 1 · –	0 · 0 · –
none of A K Q J	3 · – · –	1 · – · –	1 · – · –	0 · – · –

pass	bid 2	bid 3	bid 4

Reading the 4-handed chart

- **Almost every hand is worth a 2-bid.** The real decision is usually 2 or 3. Only about 2% of hands should pass: two small trumps and nothing else, a bare 10, or a bare 2.
- **A 4-bid needs the Jack.** Ace-King-Queen without the Jack never bids 4. With the Jack and the Ace or King, you can bid 4 with one or two small trumps, or even with none.
- **The 10 or the 2 of trump is worth about one small trump**: the 10 for Game, the 2 for Low.
- **Any one honor is a 2-bid by itself.** For 3, a bare Ace needs one small trump, a King or Jack two, and a Queen four.

6-handed (three teams of two)

Each cell: small trumps (3–9) needed to **bid 2** · **bid 3** · **bid 4**. Colour = what you can bid with no small trumps.

Your trump honors	no 10 or 2	+ 10	+ 2	+ 10 and 2
A K Q J	0 · 0 · 0	0 · 0 · 0	0 · 0 · 0	0 · 0 · 0
A K Q	0 · 0 · 1	0 · 0 · 0	0 · 0 · 0	0 · 0 · 0
A K J	0 · 0 · 0	0 · 0 · 0	0 · 0 · 0	0 · 0 · 0
A Q J	0 · 0 · 0	0 · 0 · 0	0 · 0 · 0	0 · 0 · 0
K Q J	0 · 0 · –	0 · 0 · –	0 · 0 · –	0 · 0 · –
A K	0 · 0 · 4	0 · 0 · 2	0 · 0 · 3	0 · 0 · 2
A Q	0 · 0 · –	0 · 0 · –	0 · 0 · –	0 · 0 · –
A J	0 · 0 · 2	0 · 0 · 1	0 · 0 · 1	0 · 0 · 0
K Q	0 · 4 · –	0 · 2 · –	0 · 1 · –	0 · 0 · –
K J	0 · 1 · –	0 · 0 · –	0 · 0 · –	0 · 0 · –
Q J	0 · 3 · –	0 · 1 · –	0 · 1 · –	0 · 0 · –
A	0 · 2 · –	0 · 1 · –	0 · 1 · –	0 · 0 · –
K	1 · – · –	0 · – · –	1 · 3 · –	0 · 2 · –
Q	3 · – · –	1 · – · –	1 · – · –	0 · – · –
J	2 · 5 · –	0 · 3 · –	1 · 2 · –	0 · 1 · –
none of A K Q J	5 · – · –	4 · – · –	3 · – · –	2 · – · –

pass	bid 2	bid 3	bid 4

Reading the 6-handed chart

- **About one bid tighter than 4-handed.** With two other teams against you, roughly 28% of hands should pass.
- **The Ace is the key card.** Any hand with the Ace of trump is a 2-bid. Without it, a bare King, Queen or Jack needs small trumps even to bid 2.
- **A 4-bid needs the Ace plus the Jack or King**, usually with some length.
- **A bare Ace beats two non-Ace trumps.** Holding a lone Ace in one suit and, say, K-Q in another, name the Ace's suit.

Off-suit Aces

An Ace in a side suit is worth about **half to one small trump**. **One** off-suit Ace can tip a close call up a level: 4-handed, K J plus one small trump with an Ace on the side is a 4-bid instead of a 3. **Two** off-suit Aces count as one extra small trump. They're left off the charts because they change the bid for under 1% of hands. Off-suit 10s don't change it at all.

Rules these charts assume

- 6 cards each, from a 52-card deck. 4-handed is two teams of two; 6-handed is three teams of two.
- 4 points per hand: **High** (highest trump played), **Low** (lowest trump played, scored by whoever captures it), **Jack** of trump, and **Game** (most counting cards: 10 = 10, A = 4, K = 3, Q = 2, J = 1; a tie scores nobody).
- Bids are 2, 3 or 4. The bidder leads first, and that card sets trump.
- Follow suit if you can, or trump instead. When trump is led, you must follow with trump if you can.
- Making your bid scores the points you take; failing loses the bid. The other team scores what it takes.

How the charts were made

Every possible 6-card hand was played out by computer: all 20,358,520 of them, which reduce to 962,988 distinct hands once suits are relabeled. The bidder names their best suit and plays against 224 (4-handed) or 112 (6-handed) random deals of the other cards. Every player looks ahead at each decision: it tries each card it could play against many guesses of the hidden cards and keeps the best. Each chart cell averages every hand with that trump holding, weighted by how often it's dealt. The charts give the same bid as the full per-hand results for 91% of hands (4-handed) and 88% (6-handed); most of the rest are close calls.

What the charts don't cover

- **The auction.** The charts say what a hand is worth if you play it at that bid. Taking the bid also keeps the other team from getting it cheaply. In 4-handed, opening 2 on any hand comes out even, because nearly every hand is worth 2 anyway.
- **The score.** Near the end of a game you may want to bid more or less aggressively.
- **House rules.** Variants such as a Joker, off-Jack, low to whoever was dealt it, or a 4-bid that wins the game would change the numbers.

Key takeaways

- **4-handed:** bid 2 on almost anything; the question is whether you have a 3. Save 4 for hands with the Jack.
- **6-handed:** without the Ace, you need real length; pass weak hands.
- **The 10 or 2 of trump ≈ one small trump; an off-suit Ace ≈ half to one.**
- **In the auction, raise only as far as you need** to win the bid. Overbidding to your maximum gets you set more often.